risk of being suspected of lacking objectivity, I would exempt Israeli intelligence from this assertion; I believe that it has done its job well, from the prestate period until today, and I refer here to all branches of Israeli intelligence.

I consider myself qualified to discuss the period prior to the establishment of the state, as the work I did while studying at the Hebrew University concerned the activities of the Shai, the intelligence arm of the Haganah, the forerunner of the IDF. I see myself as authorized to determine, in all modesty, that the Shai files to which I was exposed were the model of vigorous and methodical intelligence work. They gave a comprehensive picture of the Arabs in the Land of Israel in the 1940s, according to a number of indices, the principal of these being the village index (about a thousand villages on the territory of the British Mandate).

The main tool at Shai's disposal was HUMINT—the operation of agents. OSCINT—the monitoring and analysis of the Arab press— played a secondary role.

Shai succeeded in building a database of village files, in each of which the relevant intelligence officer could find his intelligence "dream come true." Each case contained what was needed to enable the intelligence officer to provide decision makers with policy and strategic recommendations and to give to the planners of the operations the material they needed to plan any type of action vis-à-vis the village. Shai's regional commanders certainly deserve kudos for carrying out professional work at the highest level within the field of intelligence.

I, along with other intelligence officials, have often encountered the cynical expression "Intelligence exists to make mistakes." My opinion, which is based on decades of intelligence work both in the field and at headquarters, at all levels and in many positions, is that intelligence is an essential tool for decision makers, enabling them to make decisions in a rational and orderly process that is not based solely on "gut feelings." Having said that, any decision, whether strategic or tactical, made in connection with the Israeli-Palestinian conflict is a function of the decision maker's political outlook. Therefore, proper groundwork in decision-making consists of the definition of a goal, the gathering of intelligence and analysis of the findings, the laying out of possible courses of action, the analysis of each course's pros and cons, and the selection of the preferred course of